

A Guide to Programming in Perl, PHP and Python

Perl, PHP and Python are three very popular and easy-to-learn programming languages, each with their own advantages and disadvantages. Newbies venturing into the field of programming will find this guide interesting and instructive.



To be a good programmer, mastering one programming language is not enough. In fact, it is very important to understand a customer's requirements and choose the best available language for the task. It's easy to shift from one programming language to another language if you know them very well. But there are so many programming languages in the world. Each has its own advantages and disadvantages. By leveraging all the advantages of different languages, a programmer can build a robust application. There are different factors which need to be considered, such as the functionality of the application, support for new features, the platform on which the application will run, performance, security, code size, community and support.

Today, let's examine the three Ps: Perl, PHP and Python. All these three languages are dynamic and powerful in their own way and can be used in different scenarios, but they are most commonly used to build Web applications and for scripting.

Perl

Perl is a general-purpose, high-level, dynamic programming language. Currently, Perl 5 is the most popular version of it, while the latest version is Perl 6. Perl is derived from different languages like C, AWK, Sed and Shell Script.

Perl is most powerful in string manipulation and regular expressions. It is very useful while parsing huge amounts of data, line by line or based on specific regex. It is also useful for Web development, systems administration, network programming and game development.

The biggest advantage of Perl is that there are many ways to do the same thing. But, sometimes, this advantage creates problems in terms of resulting in non-structural or bad code style.

Advantages

- Perl is very good at handling regular expressions. Hence, it is preferred when there is a lot of work on regex.

- Perl code is very short and there is a whole set of one-line code available, which shows the power of Perl.
- It should be used, depending upon the use case. It can be used as a functional language, sometimes object-oriented, procedural or imperative. How you want to use it depends on you. It handles almost every use case.
- Perl's CPAN provides a huge number of modules and tested code, and most of them are completely free.
- Since Perl is a very old language, it has vast community support.
- Perl is portable and available for all platforms.

Disadvantages

- Since Perl's syntax is complex, sometimes new programmers find it difficult to understand it, because the same code can be written in many different ways. For example, `print 11 + 12 + 13 != print (11 + 12) + 13`
- It has poor documentation for object-oriented paradigms compared to Python.
- In Perl, there are many ways to do the same things. Sometimes, this creates a problem.
- It is slow compared to other scripting languages.

Popularity

Though Perl has been around for a long time, its growth has been slow compared to some other languages and, yet, it has survived. Huge community support and built-in modules make it very popular.

Popular frameworks

Catalyst, Dancer, Mojolicious, etc, are some frameworks that use Perl.

Syntax

Shown below is the basic syntax for Perl. The extension for